powers to advance its rise. But emulating that is not easy for a polity like India that is characterized by greater consistency and caution. The issue, however, could end up as one less of principles than of practice.

Even in 1971, when India moved closer to the USSR, it did so in response to a new geopolitical development – the Sino-US rapprochement. By concluding the Indo-Soviet Treaty, it actually safeguarded its freedom of action rather than compromise it. Today, there is a new geopolitical challenge – the emergence of multipolarity. It surely does not call for a response as drastic as 1971, but definitely encourages a widening of India's options and understandings. The objective is to create a better balance and working closely with converging interests. As China itself has demonstrated, working with others is an integral element of an upward trajectory. Only those who lack self-confidence will doubt the wisdom of doing so. It is important that India not be either persuaded nor pressurized to restrict its options.

A rising China seeks to shape Asia, perhaps even the world, to its architectural vision. Many of its key plans are unilateral enterprises. The Belt and Road Initiative (BRI) appears to serve its national objectives and conscious collaboration is naturally for those who envisage convergence with those goals. The issue is not about connectivity in itself; there is an obvious paucity of that in a continent distorted by colonial history. India has supported a range of initiatives within the country, in its South Asian and maritime periphery, to South-East Asia and to West Asia and beyond. But these are all consultative endeavours based on broadly accepted commercial principles and goals. India is comfortable with the connectivity contributions of the Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank and the BRICS New Development Bank. China has a key role in both institutions.

A concern arises when there is a departure from norms and transparency, that too to serve a limited agenda. In May 2017, India took the lead in the global debate on connectivity. It stated publicly that connectivity initiatives must be based on universally recognized international norms, good governance, rule of law, openness, transparency and equality. They must also follow principles of financial responsibility to avoid projects that would create unsustainable debt burdens for communities. They should